Subjects taught in Standards 1 to 10

A natural-language overview for Indian schools following a CBSE-aligned curriculum

How to use this guide
This document describes common school subject areas and how they generally develop from Standard 1 through Standard 10. It is a broad overview, not an official year-specific syllabus. The exact subjects, names, language choices, electives, and lesson sequence can vary by school and academic year.

At the primary level, learning is usually broad and activity-based. In middle school, subjects become more distinct. In secondary school, students study core subjects and may have choices among languages, academic electives, and skill subjects.

The descriptions below use “subject” broadly. Art, physical education, work experience, and well-being may be taught as regular classes, integrated activities, or school-based components rather than as conventional examination subjects.

Standards 1-5: Primary learning

In the early standards, schools commonly build literacy, numeracy, curiosity about the surrounding world, creativity, and healthy habits. Some schools teach environmental topics through an integrated subject; others use separate subject names.

Standard 1

Children begin formal learning in one or more languages through listening, speaking, reading, and early writing. Mathematics introduces numbers, counting, shapes, patterns, and simple everyday problem-solving. They also explore their family, school, community, nature, and daily life through integrated environmental or “world around us” activities. Art, music, movement, play, and physical education support expression and healthy development.

Standard 2

Language learning continues through stories, conversation, reading, and writing short pieces. Mathematics builds confidence with number operations, measurement, shapes, and simple reasoning. Children continue to study their surroundings, including people, places, plants, animals, and responsible habits. Creative arts, music, games, and physical activities remain part of a balanced school day.

Standard 3

Students strengthen reading comprehension, writing, speaking, and language skills in their chosen languages. Mathematics develops further through arithmetic, measurement, geometry, and problem-solving. Environmental Studies, often called EVS, commonly brings together basic ideas about the natural and social world. Schools may also introduce age-appropriate computer or digital learning, alongside art, music, and physical education.

Standard 4

Students read a wider range of texts and write more organised descriptions and explanations in their languages. Mathematics extends to larger numbers, operations, fractions or introductory parts of a whole, measurement, and geometry. EVS develops observation and understanding of the environment, community, health, and resources. Schools continue creative arts and physical education, and may offer introductory computing.

Standard 5

Students develop more independent reading, writing, discussion, and language use. Mathematics focuses on applying operations, fractions, decimals, measurement, shapes, and data to practical problems. EVS deepens understanding of people, ecosystems, health, and the environment, helping prepare students for more distinct Science and Social Science subjects in middle school. Art, music, physical education, and digital skills may continue, depending on the school.

Standards 6-8: Middle school

In middle school, the curriculum typically separates learning into subject areas and gives students more opportunities to investigate, explain, practise, and apply ideas.

Standard 6

Students study languages, Mathematics, Science, and Social Science. Science introduces more systematic work with living things, materials, motion, energy, and the environment. Social Science usually includes history, geography, and civics or social and political life. Schools may also include art education, physical education and well-being, work or vocational activities, and computer education or computational thinking.

Standard 7

Students continue language study and develop stronger reading, writing, and communication skills. Mathematics adds depth to number work, fractions, integers, algebraic thinking, geometry, and data. Science explores concepts in biology, chemistry, and physics through age-appropriate themes and practical activities. Social Science develops historical, geographical, and civic understanding. Art, physical education, work education, and digital or skill learning may also be part of the programme.

Standard 8

Students consolidate their languages, Mathematics, Science, and Social Science before entering secondary school. They practise multi-step mathematical reasoning and investigate scientific ideas in more detail. History, geography, and civics help them connect societies, places, resources, and institutions. Depending on the school, students may also study a third language, computer or digital studies, art, physical education, and introductory vocational or skill modules.

Common middle-school subject names: Languages; Mathematics; Science; Social Science (History, Geography, and Civics); Art Education; Physical Education and Well-being; and, where offered, Work Education, Computer Education, or skill modules.

Standards 9-10: Secondary school

At the secondary level, students generally take language subjects, Mathematics, Science, and Social Science. Schools and board schemes may provide choices in languages, levels, academic electives, and skill subjects. The exact combination should be checked against the school's current subject list.

Standard 9

Students usually study two languages, Mathematics, Science, and Social Science. Science is commonly organised around Biology, Chemistry, and Physics concepts. Social Science commonly covers History, Geography, Political Science or Civics, and Economics. Depending on the applicable curriculum and the school, students may also take an elective or skill subject. Art Education, Physical Education and Well-being, work experience, and general studies may be included as school-based areas.

Standard 10

Students generally continue with languages, Mathematics, Science, and Social Science, preparing for the relevant board examinations. The Science course brings together Biology, Chemistry, and Physics topics, while Social Science covers areas such as History, Geography, Political Science or Civics, and Economics. Subject choices can include approved academic or skill electives, subject to the board scheme and the school's offerings. Health and Physical Education, work experience, and general studies may also form part of the school programme.

When answering a student or parent, confirm the board, school, standard, and academic year. This guide cannot establish the exact subjects or syllabus for a particular school.

Sources and scope

This overview draws on the National Curriculum Framework for the Foundational Stage (NCERT, 2022), which describes early learning and curricular areas, and CBSE curriculum information for secondary classes. It is written as a general explainer and does not reproduce a board syllabus.

NCERT, National Curriculum Framework for the Foundational Stage (2022): https://ncert.nic.in/pdf/focus-group/NCF-FS_2022EN.pdf

CBSE Academics, Curriculum for Academic Year 2026-27: https://cbseacademic.nic.in/curriculum_2027.html

CBSE Academics, Skill Education and Scheme of Studies (2026-27): https://cbseacademic.nic.in/skill-education.html